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# Metro Celebrates Nearly $900 Million Grant for East SFV Light Rail Project

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The Los Angeles Metropolitan Transportation Authority (Metro) received a major boost in federal funding to the tune of $893 million towards the completion of the light rail line that will connect Van Nuys to Pacoima by 2031.

The grant, from the United States Department of Transportation, is for the southern segment of the East San Fernando Valley Light Rail Transit (ESFV LRT) Project, which will be a 6.7-mile line starting at the Metro's Bus Rapid Transit G Line (Orange) and heads north through Panorama City and Arleta. The project may include a northern segment – a 2.5-mile stretch connecting Pacoima, the City of San Fernando and Sylmar.

Metro previously received $700 million in federal funding through the Bipartisan Infrastructure Bill, $66.9 million of which is being used to help fund the southern segment of the ESFV LRT.

The ceremony for the nearly $900 million grant was held in the courtyard of the Van Nuys Civic Center on Friday, Sept. 6.

Local, state and federal officials all attended, including Congressman Tony Cárdenas, Sen. Alex Padilla, LA City Councilmember Monica Rodriguez, LA County Supervisor Lindsey Horvath, State Sen. Caroline Menjivar and Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel.

They all wanted to be present as supporters of this major project that will return local stop rail service.

It's historic – a full circle undertaking, after the Pacific Electric trains, nicknamed the Red Cars, stopped running in the valley in 1952. Established in the 1920s, these trains ran on the largest electric railway system in the world connecting cities in LA, Orange, Riverside and San Bernardino counties.

Many Angelenos and those living throughout the region were disheartened to see the Red Car trains go, which soon after, resulted in more automobiles on the road and decades later, the gridlock we have today.

The decline of the Red Car was impacted by the strong push from the automobile manufacturers at General Motors. Gas rationing during World War II that had increased streetcar ridership was lifted, and transportation funding went to constructing highways and freeways. Car ownership became necessary. It was regarded as the most efficient mode of transportation and was knitted into LA's lifestyle and cultural status.

Return to Connecting Communities

"We are bringing back local commuter rail service to the San Fernando Valley, which has been missing for more than 70 years," Jacquelyn Dupont-Walker, second vice chair on Metro's Board of Directors said.

"I am so pleased that we will be doing our part to ensure residents will be able to benefit from what is being built in their neighborhoods."

Dupont-Walker added that Metro is incorporating a "cultural competency component" into the project, meaning the contractor "must incorporate race, ethnicity, gender, immigration status, languages spoken, socioeconomics and public transit dependencies … as part of this contract."

Dave Sotero, Metro's communications director, explained that this component will provide community engagement with residents living in areas affected by the construction of the light rail and will include strategies specifically for

businesses.

The light rail construction will take place through Van Nuys Boulevard, already a major thoroughfare for commuters and lined with hundreds of storefronts and businesses in the communities of Van Nuys, Panorama City, Arleta and Pacoima.

To mitigate anticipated disruption, The Business Interruption Fund (BIF), will be offered to provide financial assistance to small businesses impacted by the rail construction. Businesses will be able to file multiple requests for assistance, but the amount they receive can't exceed the lesser amount of $60,000 or 60% of annual revenue losses per business. The funds can be used for rent, insurance, utilities and payroll expenses.

There is an advisory board called the Community Leadership Council (CLC) composed of 15 individuals who live, work, attend school or own a business or commercial property within the affected neighborhoods. Each member will serve a two-year term, hold quarterly community meetings and will work with Metro staff on project-related issues.

Additionally, Metro has the Eat Shop Play program, which helps eligible businesses located along Metro Rail construction projects sign up for marketing assistance. This can include print and digital ads and marketing through social media and email.

Metro will also have a traffic management plan to mitigate the impact construction will have on the affected businesses and will send out notices in advance detailing when it will take place.

"It's not our first time building a major rail line in a very busy corridor," Sotero said. "The D Line Subway Extension Project was built underneath Wilshire Boulevard, so that's an even busier street. … We've been successful in mitigating construction work for several years now because it's a multi-year construction project, so we're going to bring those lessons learned to the San Fernando Valley."

He acknowledged that Van Nuys Boulevard is one of the busiest streets in the valley, so Metro is putting in a new rail line where one is needed the most.

"It's that connectivity that valley residents will be able to [utilize] to get from one area to the other, and they can go throughout Los Angeles County with our existing system," Sotero said. "I can't underestimate the importance of this rail project for the valley because it does create those important, critical connections for the valley."

For more information about BIF and how to apply, go to https://www.metro.net/about/business-interruption-fund/.

To contact the CLC, call 818-701-3844 or email eastsfvtransit@metro.net.

To register for the Eat Shop Play program, visit https://www.metro.net/about/eat-shop-play/.

Editor Diana Martinez contributed to this article.

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